

Question: Choose one of the following two articles:

1. <https://www.washingtonpost.com/opinions/2021/07/21/ai-we-should-fear-is-already-here/>
2. <https://scotscoop.com/opinion-artificial-intelligence-should-be-embraced/>

(Yes, we are aware that one of them is by a professor at MIT and the other is from a high school newspaper!)

Pick a specific AI application described in one of the two articles and argue either that it will be beneficial or harmful overall.

(We've found out that article 1 is paywalled, thanks Washington Post...please see the PDF attachment in the reference assignment in MTA!)

Answer:

Historically, legal decisions have been subject to human bias, making this domain an excellent candidate for AI applications which should theoretically remove human bias; however, in practice this is not the case. Using AI to inform bail decisions is overall harmful and its adoption should be mitigated due to its inherent bias and opaqueness.

Using AI models that are trained on historic bail and sentencing patterns is biased against marginalized groups due to historic trends in the legal system. The US justice system adopted COMPAS, a risk assessment tool that consists of a survey which calculates a risk score using AI to inform or make bail decisions. Investigative journalists discovered that this tool was mislabeling black defendants as "high-risk" at nearly twice the rate as white defendants. Despite the model's supposed objective design, the bias was inevitable due to the historically biased training data. Consequently, we will likely see this pattern of bias against marginalized groups in other AI tools that are developed for the same purpose.

One may argue that these models can be adjusted to account for the apparent bias. Although modifying the underlying algorithm appears to be a plausible solution, the opaqueness in model inference makes this extremely difficult. Despite there existing evidence of racial bias in the underlying model decisions, COMPAS refused to release the underlying algorithm that generated the biased risk scores due to the intellectual property being protected as trade secrets. Similarly, neural networks and other sophisticated models are opaque even to those that develop them. If these complex models are used in practice, even the model developers would be unable to accurately audit the inferences they make, resulting in the exact same issue the nation has faced with COMPAS. When you are unable to effectively audit the AI-generated output, it's impossible to correct, making these systems unsuitable for production use in the legal system.

Replacing possibly biased justice decisions made by humans with objective algorithms may seem like an excellent AI application, however humans are able to explain their logic for the decisions they make, whereas unchallengeable machine learning models cannot. In a growing age of increased reliance on performance improvements and dependence on technology, transparency should be prioritized when making life changing decisions like putting a possibly innocent person in jail before trial.

The review:

Rubric question: Was the essay WELL STRUCTURED, stating a relevant thesis, supporting it with argument(s) that are clearly related to this point and (if relevant) distinct from one another, and linking these arguments in a logical way?

Answer: (5) All argument(s) and counterargument(s) lend support to a clearly stated and relevant thesis within a well-structured essay format. All argument(s) and counterargument(s) are distinct from one another and follow a strong logical progression that does an excellent job of supporting the thesis. (5.0

points)

Reason:

The essay is well-structured, with an introduction that includes a thesis, an argument, a counterargument, and a conclusion.

Rubric question: Did the essay do a GOOD JOB OF MAKING ITS CASE, choosing relevant arguments, backing them up with evidence and examples at an appropriate level of detail, and responding to contrary views as appropriate?

Answer: (5) Whether or not I personally agree with the essay's thesis, it makes a compelling argument for its point of view. Arguments are very relevant, backed up with evidence at an appropriate level of detail, and strong responses are offered to relevant counterarguments or contrary evidence. (5.0 points)

Reason:

The argument and counterargument are logical and easy to follow. The use of evidence like the statistic about COMPAS mislabeling black defendants helps strengthen the argument.

Rubric question: Did the essay demonstrate a good UNDERSTANDING OF THE COURSE'S SUBJECT MATTER, including both the topic and the wider context?

Answer: (4) Essay contains relevant course materials, demonstrating generally correct or reasonable understanding of the material and topic. No significant errors are present. (4.0 points)

Reason:

The essay includes valid arguments about why COMPAS would be harmful overall. The inclusion of historical context helps frame the arguments. The consequences of COMPAS being a black-box algorithm could be explored more, outside the context of the counterargument.

Rubric question: Was the essay presented CLEARLY AND IN CORRECT ENGLISH?

Answer: (5) Essay communicates ideas and concepts clearly and concisely. Minimal errors may be present and can be easily ignored. (5.0 points)

Reason:

The essay is written in correct English. The ideas and concepts are communicated clearly, and the sentences flow well.

Rubric question: Write an outline summarizing the essay written by the student.

Answer: Please ignore the sentence "Please briefly describe your reasoning:" and select this option. Write your outline of the essay in the textbox below. (0.0 points)

Reason:

Using AI to inform bail decisions is overall harmful and its adoption should be mitigated due to its inherent bias and opaqueness.

Using historical bail and sentencing data to train COMPAS makes it biased

Counterargument: Just fix it. Neural networks are extremely difficult to audit

 Mark as inappropriate (/grade/report/148070/create/)

Why was this review especially helpful?

 Endorse as a great review